

The Ultimate Guide to Swiss German

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00 Introduction

Swiss German is a continuum of Alemannic dialects spoken across German-speaking Switzerland. This guide is focused on **Zürich German**, the dialect of the canton and city of Zürich, specifically the city dialect.

This guide assumes a working knowledge of **Standard German** (cases, gender, verb conjugation, separable prefixes), and focuses on how Zürich German differs from it. There is no single standardized spelling for Swiss German; this guide uses the *Dieth-Schreibung* conventions where practical.

Dialect and Hochdeutsch

German-speaking Switzerland is *diglossic*. Dialect is the spoken language for almost everything: family, work, shops, local radio and TV. Hochdeutsch (*Schriftdütsch*) is mainly written, and spoken in school, on the national news, and with people who don't understand dialect. Even Swiss Hochdeutsch has its own accent and words (*Velo*, *parkieren*).

- Expect people to switch to Hochdeutsch or English when they hear you. Ask them to stay in dialect: **Chönd Sie Mundart mit mir rede?**
- Text messages are often written in dialect, spelled however the writer likes. Reading them is great practice.

How to use this guide

- **01–05**: sounds and grammar, always compared with Hochdeutsch.
- **06–07**: the phrases and vocabulary to learn first.
- **08–09**: sentences and a dialogue to read aloud.
- **10**: pronunciation and intonation, i.e. the accent itself.
- **11**: films, series, podcasts and music to keep going.
- In tables, a *small grey italic line* gives the Hochdeutsch equivalent.

01 Phonology

Sound shifts from Standard German

Most differences between Standard German and Zürich German are predictable from a handful of historical sound correspondences. In several cases, Zürich German simply *preserves* a Middle High German form that Standard German has since monophthongized or diphthongized.

A *monophthong* is a single vowel sound (like the *ee* in *see*); a *diphthong* is a vowel sound that glides from one position to another (like the *oy* in *boy* or the *ow* in *now*). To *monophthongize* is to collapse a diphthong into a single vowel; to *diphthongize* is the reverse.

SHIFT	STANDARD GERMAN	ZÜRICH GERMAN	NOTES
[aʊ] → [uː]	Haus, Ausgang	Huus, Uusgang	Only where Standard German *au* comes from Middle High German /uː/. See au → uu.
[aɪ] → [iː]	Schweiz, Zeit, Wein	Schwiiz, Ziit, Wii	Only where SG *ei* comes from MHG /iː/. Where it comes from MHG /ei/, it stays as *ei*: *Stein* → *Stei*.
[iː] → [iə]	Liebe, Brief	Liebi, Briäf	Zürich German preserves MHG /ie/, /uo/, /üe/. SG monophthongized them.
[uː] → [uə]	Fuß, gut, Bruder	Fuess, guet, Brueder	Same pattern as above: preserves MHG /uo/.
[ɔɪ] → [yː]	Deutsch, Freund, heute	Tüütsch, Fründ, hüt	SG *eu*/*äu* from MHG /iu/ stays as *ü*(*ü*).
[k] → [x] / [kx]	Kind, Kalt, Kuchen	Chind, chalt, Chueche	The famous Swiss *ch*. See below.

Final `-n` is dropped almost everywhere: *machen* → *mache*, *kommen* → *choo*. The infinitive ending `-en` reduces to `-e`. Inside words and at word-end, *st* and *sp* are pronounced (and in Dieth often *written*) *scht* / *schp*, so *ist* → *isch*, *bist* → *bisch*, *Fest* → *Fescht*, *Post* → *Poscht*. Word-initially they stay written as *st-*/*sp-* but are still pronounced *scht*/*schp*.

The `k` → `ch` / `kx` shift

High Alemannic completed the second Germanic consonant shift further than Standard German did. Native /k/ became the velar fricative `[x]` (written *ch*) word-initially. Loanwords from Standard German that entered later get the affricate `[kx]` instead.

NATIVE K → CH [X]

Kind → **Chind**
kalt → **chalt**
Kuchen → **Chueche**
Küche → **Chuchi**
Kopf → **Chopf**
kommen → **choo**
danken → **danche**

LOANWORD K → KX

Kafi (*Kaffee*)
Kanton
Kino
Kampf
Kanal

These are written with *k* but pronounced with a noticeably "harder" onset than Standard German.

The `au → uu` shift in detail

Words where Standard German *au* comes from MHG /u:/ shift to *uu*. Words where it comes from MHG /ou/ keep a diphthong (often *au* in Zürich, *ou* in other regions).

SHIFTS TO UU

Auszeit → **Uusziit**
Aufbau → **Uufbuu**
Bauch → **Buuch**
Faust → **Fuust**
Kraut → **Chruut**
Laus → **Luus**
Maus → **Muus**
Strauch → **Struuch**
Schaufel → **Schuufle**
Haut → **Huut**
laut → **luut**
sauber → **suuber**

STAYS A DIPHTHONG

Auto
Auge → **Aug**
Pause
Lauch
Rauch → **Rauch / Rouch**
Zauberer
kaufen → **chaufe**
laufen → **laufe**
Frau

There is no way to see the MHG origin from the spelling, so learn the common *uu* words as vocabulary. A useful hint: if a word has *ou* in Bernese or Basel German (*Ouge*, *choufe*), it keeps a diphthong in Zürich too.

Other regular correspondences

Beyond the big vowel shifts, a handful of smaller patterns let you "translate" most Hochdeutsch words into Zürich German on the fly. They are tendencies, not laws, but they hold often enough to be worth learning as rules of thumb.

PATTERN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ZÜRICH GERMAN	NOTE
e → *ä*	Berg, Weg, Leben, gern	**Bärg, Wäg, Läbe, gärn**	Very open *ä*, like English *cat*.
o → *u* before *m, n*	Sonne, Sommer, Woche, Sonntag	**Sunne, Summer, Wuche, Sunntig**	Also in many other short *o* words.
-ung → *-ig*	Zeitung, Wohnung, Rechnung	**Ziitig, Wonig, Rächnig**	Very regular; works on almost any *-ung* noun.
-chen → *-li*	Mädchen, Brötchen	**Meitli, Brötli**	See Diminutive -li.
final *-e* dropped	Katze, Schule, Ende	**Chatz, Schuel, Änd**	Common in feminine nouns.
-en → *-e*	machen, Garten, Wagen	**mache, Garte, Wage**	The *n* comes back before a vowel.
ge- → *g-*	gemacht, gesagt, gegangen	**gmacht, gseit, ggange**	No vowel in the prefix; see Perfekt.
au → *u* in short words	auf, aus, darauf	**uf, us, druf**	Mostly prepositions and prefixes.

🇨🇭	Am Sunntig lis ich d Ziitig im Garte.
🇩🇪	Am Sonntag lese ich die Zeitung im Garten.
🇬🇧	On Sundays I read the paper in the garden.

🇨🇭	Ich ha d Rächnig i de Wonig vergässe.
🇩🇪	Ich habe die Rechnung in der Wohnung vergessen.
🇬🇧	I forgot the bill in the flat.

02 Articles

From here on, the *small grey italic line* under a Swiss form in a table is its Standard German (Hochdeutsch) equivalent.

Articles follow the same gender / number / case logic as Standard German, with two important caveats:

- The **genitive case does not exist** in spoken Swiss German. Possession is expressed via *vo* + dative, or by a possessive-dative construction (see below).
- Several article forms come in **long / short variants**, the longer form is used before a vowel, the shorter one before a consonant.

Definite article

	MASCULINE	NEUTER	FEMININE	PLURAL
Nominative	de(r)* *der*	s *das*	d *die*	d *die*
Accusative	de(n)* *den*	s *das*	d *die*	d *die*
Dative	em *dem*	em *dem*	de(r)* *der*	de(n)* *den*

* The longer forms (in parentheses) are used when a vowel follows, the shorter ones before a consonant. *De Maa* (the man) vs. *der Esel* (the donkey).

Indefinite article

	MASCULINE	NEUTER	FEMININE
Nominative, Accusative	en *ein / einen*	es *ein*	e(n)* *eine*
Dative	emene(n)* *einem*	emene(n)* *einem*	enere(n)* *einer*

Short dative forms *eme(n)* (m/n) also occur; the longer forms are more typical of Zürich.

Negative article

	MASCULINE	NEUTER	FEMININE	PLURAL
Nominative, Accusative	kein *kein / keinen*	keis *kein*	kei *keine*	keini *keine*
Dative	keim *keinem*	keim *keinem*	keinere(n) *keiner*	keine *keinen*

Articles before personal names

In Zürich German, and most Swiss German dialects, personal names **almost always take an article**. *De Hans*, *d Anna*, *s Lisi*.

🇨🇭	De Hans het mer s Buech ggää.
🇩🇪	Hans hat mir das Buch gegeben.
🇬🇧	Hans gave me the book.

Family words and many girls' names take the **neuter** article *s*: *s Mami*, *s Grosi* (grandma), *s Anni*, *s Lisi*. Diminutive name forms in *-li* are always neuter: *s Anneli*.

Expressing possession (no genitive)

Because there is no genitive, possession is expressed two ways:

- **vo + dative:** *s Velo vom Peter* (Peter's bike).
- **Possessive-dative construction:** *em Peter sis Velo* (lit. "to-the Peter his bike"). The possessor is in the dative and followed by a possessive pronoun agreeing with the possessed item.

🇨🇭	Em Peter sis Velo isch kapuut.
🇩🇪	Peters Fahrrad ist kaputt.
🇬🇧	Peter's bike is broken.

🇨🇭	Das isch em Grosi sis Huus.
🇩🇪	Das ist Omas Haus.
🇬🇧	That's grandma's house.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ENGLISH
Wem ghört das?	Wem gehört das?	Whose is this?
Das ghört mir. / Das isch mis.	Das gehört mir. / Das ist meins.	It's mine.
Isch das dis Velo?	Ist das dein Fahrrad?	Is that your bike?
Nei, das isch em Peter sis.	Nein, das ist Peters.	No, it's Peter's.
D Wonig vo minere Schwöschter	die Wohnung meiner Schwester	my sister's flat

Prepositions merge with the article

Because the articles are so short, they fuse with the preposition in front of them, much more than in Hochdeutsch (*im*, *am*, *zum*). You will hear these merged forms constantly; they're also what makes names with articles sound natural.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	EXAMPLE
ufem	auf dem	*Ufem Tisch liit es Buech.* *Auf dem Tisch liegt ein Buch.*
mitem	mit dem	*Ich fahre mitem Tram.* *Ich fahre mit der Tram.*
bim	beim	*Mir träffed öis bim Bahnhof.* *Wir treffen uns beim Bahnhof.*
usem	aus dem	*Er chunt grad usem Huus.* *Er kommt gerade aus dem Haus.*
vorem	vor dem	*Mir warted vorem Kino.* *Wir warten vor dem Kino.*
hinderem	hinter dem	*Hinderem Huus isch en Garte.* *Hinter dem Haus ist ein Garten.*
ide	in der / in die	*Si wohnt ide Stadt.* *Sie wohnt in der Stadt.*
is	ins	*Gömmer hüt Abig is Kino?* *Gehen wir heute Abend ins Kino?*
zum	zum	*Ich gang morn zum Coiffeur.* *Ich gehe morgen zum Friseur.*
z	in / nach (places)	*Ich wohne z Züri.* *Ich wohne in Zürich.*

Direction words

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	EXAMPLE
ine	hinein, herein	*Chum ine!* *Komm herein!*
use	hinaus, heraus	*Gang use go spile!* *Geh hinaus spielen!*
ufe	hinauf, herauf	*Mir laufed uf de Uetliberg ufe.* *Wir laufen auf den Uetliberg hinauf.*
abe	hinunter, herunter	*Si chunt d Stäge abe.* *Sie kommt die Treppe herunter.*

03 Pronouns

Personal pronouns

Most pronouns track Standard German closely. The biggest differences: *wir* → *mir*, *uns* → *öis* / *üs*, *euch* → *öi*. Many forms have a **strong** (stressed) and a **weak / clitic** (unstressed) variant; both are listed below where they differ.

PERSON	NOMINATIVE	ACCUSATIVE	DATIVE
1 sg	ich / i *ich*	mich / mi *mich*	mir / mer *mir*
2 sg	du *du*	dich / di *dich*	dir / der *dir*
3 sg m	är / er *er*	in / en *ihn*	im / em *ihm*
3 sg n	es / s *es*	es / s *es*	im / em *ihm*
3 sg f	si *sie*	si / se *sie*	ere / re *ihr*
1 pl	mir / mer *wir*	öis / üs *uns*	öis / üs *uns*
2 pl	iir / er *ihr*	öi *euch*	öi *euch*
3 pl	si *sie*	si / se *sie*	ene *ihnen*

The reflexive pronoun is *mi* / *di* / *sich* / *sich* / *sich* / *öis* / *öi* / *sich*, only third-person has a special form (the universal *sich*); other persons reuse the accusative.

Possessive pronouns (*min, din, sin, ire*)

Same gender / number / case logic as Standard German. The first-person singular paradigm shown below; *din* (your sg.), *sin* (his / its), *ire* (her / their), *öise*(*r*) (our), *öie*(*r*) (your pl.) follow the same pattern.

	MASCULINE	NEUTER	FEMININE	PLURAL
Nominative	min *mein*	mis *mein*	mini *meine*	mini *meine*
Accusative	min / mine(n) *meinen*	mis *mein*	mini *meine*	mini *meine*
Dative	mim *meinem*	mim *meinem*	minere(n) *meiner*	mine(n) *meinen*

04 Verbs

The verb system is where Swiss German diverges most from Standard German. The main differences:

1. **All three plural persons share the same form.** The 1st, 2nd, and 3rd person plural conjugate identically. Weak verbs take `-ed` (*mir mached*, *ir mached*, *si mached*); most irregular verbs and modals take `-nd` (*mir gönd*, *ir gönd*, *si gönd*).
2. There is **no preterite**. Past tense is always the Perfekt.
3. Future tense is usually expressed by the present tense with an adverb (*morn*, *spöter*). The *wärde*-future (*wärde* + infinitive) exists but is used less freely than in Standard German.
4. Several auxiliary verbs are **"doubled"** with a particle *go*, *cho*, or *la*.
5. The **Konjunktiv II** with `-ti` survives and is in everyday use (whereas the preterite that it's built on has disappeared).

Core irregular verbs

The plural *-nd* ending fuses with a postposed pronoun: *gönd* + *mir* = *gömer* ("we go" / "shall we go"), *hend* + *mir* = *hender* / *hemmer* ("we have"), *sind* + *mir* = *simer* ("we are").

	SII (SEIN)	HAA (HABEN)	GAH (GEHEN)	TUE (TUN)	WERDE (WERDEN)
ich	bi(n)	ha(n)	gang / gah	tue(n)	wird
du	bisch	hesch	gaasch	tuesch	wirsch
er / sie / es	isch	het	gaat	tuet	wird
mir / ihr / Sie	sind	hend	gönd	tüend	werded
PARTICIPLE	*gsii*	*ghaa*	*ggange*	*taa*	*worde*

Sandhi: word-final *-n* resurfaces before a vowel-initial pronoun or particle, *ich bi-n-en gsee* ("I saw him").

Regular (weak) verbs

	MACHE (MACHEN)	REDE (REDEN)	WARTE (WARTEN)
ich	mache	rede	warte
du	machsch	redsch	wartsch
er / sie / es	macht	redt	wartet
mir / ihr / Sie	mached	reded	warted
PARTICIPLE	*gmacht*	*gredt*	*gwartet*

Modal verbs

	WELE (WOLLEN)	MÜESE (MÜSSEN)	TÖRFFE (DÜRFEN)	SÖLE (SOLLEN)	CHÖNE (KÖNNEN)	MÖGE (MÖGEN)
ich	wott	mues	törf	söll	cha(n)	mag
du	wottsch	muesch	törfsch	söllsch	chasch	magsch
er / sie / es	wott	mues	törf	söll	cha	mag
mir / ihr / Sie	wänd	müend	törfed	sölled	chönd	möged
PARTICIPLE	*wele*	*müese*	*törffe*	*sölle*	*chöne*	*möge*

More irregular verbs

	WÜSSE (WISSEN)	GÄÄ (GEBEN)	NÄÄ (NEHMEN)	GSEE (SEHEN)	GSCHEE (GESCHEHEN)
ich	weiss	gibe	nime	gsee(n)	,
du	weisch	gisch	nimsch	gseesch	,
er / sie / es	weiss	git	nimt	gseet	gscheet
mir / ihr / Sie	wüssed	gänd	nämed	gseend	,
PARTICIPLE	*gwüsst*	*ggää*	*gnoo*	*gsee*	*gschee*

Note that for *gsee* (“to see”) the past participle is identical to the infinitive: *Ich han en gsee* (“I saw him”).

Modal verbs in use

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ENGLISH
Ich mag nöd.	Ich habe keine Lust.	I can’t be bothered.
Du muesch nöd cho.	Du musst nicht kommen.	You don’t have to come.
Törf ich da rauche?	Darf ich hier rauchen?	May I smoke here?
Wottsch no es Bier?	Willst du noch ein Bier?	Want another beer?
Ich cha kei Französisch.	Ich kann kein Französisch.	I don’t speak French.

möge often means “to feel like / have the energy”: *Ich mag nüme* = I can’t go on, I’ve had enough.

No preterite, use the Perfekt

Swiss German has no preterite / simple past tense. Whatever past tense you want to express, you build the **Perfekt** with *haa* or *sii* + past participle. This is true of all spoken Swiss German.

🇩🇪	Gestern war ich zu Hause.
🇨🇭	Gester bini dihei gsii.

VERB	PERFECT TENSE	EXAMPLE
gah (gehen)	ich bin ggange	*Ich bi go poschte ggange.* *Ich bin einkaufen gegangen.*
esse (essen)	ich ha gesse	*Mir hend Fondue gesse.* *Wir haben Fondue gegessen.*
haa (haben)	ich ha ___ ghaa	*Ich han es Käffeli ghaa.* *Ich habe einen kleinen Kaffee gehabt.*
gsee (sehen)	ich ha ___ gsee	*Hesch en gsee?* *Hast du ihn gesehen?*
sii (sein)	ich bin ___ gsii	*Das isch alles gsii.* *Das ist alles gewesen.*

haa or *sii*? Common participles

Auxiliaries follow Hochdeutsch, with one Swiss twist: **stah, sitze, ligge** (stand, sit, lie) take *sii*.

VERB	PARTICIPLE	AUX.	EXAMPLE
stah (stehen)	gstande	sii	*Ich bi im Tram gstande.* *Ich habe in der Tram gestanden.*
sitze (sitzen)	gsässe	sii	*Mir sind de ganz Abig dusse gsässe.* *Wir haben den ganzen Abend draußen gesessen.*
choo (kommen)	cho	sii	*Bisch guet hei cho?* *Bist du gut nach Hause gekommen?*
schaffe (arbeiten)	gschaffet	haa	*Ich ha de ganz Tag gschaffet.* *Ich habe den ganzen Tag gearbeitet.*

For the pluperfect, Swiss German doubles the Perfekt: *Ich ha scho gesse ghaa, won er cho isch* ("Ich hatte schon gegessen, als er kam").

Subjunctive II (Konjunktiv II)

Even though the preterite is gone, the *Konjunktiv II* built from it survives and is in daily use for hypotheticals, polite requests, and counterfactuals. It's typically formed with the suffix `-ti` on the verb stem, often clipped to `-t` in the singular. *Würde* + infinitive is unusual; the synthetic form is preferred.

VERB	KONJUNKTIV II (1SG)	EXAMPLE
sii (sein)	ich wär / wäri	*Wenn ich riich wär …* *Wenn ich reich wäre …*
haa (haben)	ich het / hetti	*Ich hetti gern es Bier.* *Ich hätte gern ein Bier.*
gah (gehen)	ich gieng / göng	*Ich gieng au gern mit.* *Ich ginge auch gern mit.*
chöne (können)	ich chönt / chönti	*Chöntsch mer hälfe?* *Könntest du mir helfen?*
wele (wollen)	ich wett / wetti	*Ich wett en Kafi.* *Ich möchte einen Kaffee.*
müese (müssen)	ich müesst / müessti	*Du müesstisch früener cho.* *Du müsstest früher kommen.*
tue (tun)	ich täät / täti	*Ich täti scho cho, wenn …* *Ich würde schon kommen, wenn …*
choo (kommen)	ich chäm / chämti	*Chämsch morn?* *Kämst du morgen?*

Polite ordering, *Ich hetti gern …*, is the equivalent of "I'd like …" in restaurants and shops, and is one of the most useful Konjunktiv II forms to drill.

Polite requests and hypotheticals

🇨🇭 Chönnt ich bitte es Glas Wasser ha?

🇩🇪 Könnte ich bitte ein Glas Wasser haben?

🇬🇧 Could I have a glass of water, please?

🇨🇭 Hettsch Luscht, morn mitzcho?

🇩🇪 Hättest du Lust, morgen mitzukommen?

🇬🇧 Would you like to come along tomorrow?

Doubled verbs (*go*, *cho*, *la*)

A small set of motion / causative verbs, *gah*, *choo*, *laa*, *aafaa*, spawn a "doubled" particle when chained with another verb. The doubled form is a clitic-like marker that sits in front of the main verb.

VERB	DOUBLED FORM	ENGLISH
gah (gehen)	go	to go
choo (kommen)	cho	to come
laa (lassen)	la	to let
aafaa (anfangen)	aa	to begin

 Ich gang go poschte.

 Ich gehe einkaufen.

 I'm going (out) shopping.

 Chum cho esse!

 Komm essen!

 Come eat!

 La mich la mache!

 Lass mich machen!

 Let me do it!

go, *cho* and *la* in everyday speech

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ENGLISH
Ich gang go schaffe.	Ich gehe arbeiten.	I'm going to work.
Mir gönd go schwümme.	Wir gehen schwimmen.	We're going swimming.
Chunsch cho luege?	Kommst du schauen?	Are you coming to have a look?
Gömmer go ässe?	Gehen wir essen?	Shall we go eat?
Ich la s Velo la flicke.	Ich lasse das Fahrrad reparieren.	I'm having the bike repaired.

The *tue*-periphrasis

Alemannic dialects (Swiss German among them) use *tue* + infinitive much more readily than Standard German. The construction marks durative or progressive aspect (*Mir tüend grad es Bild ufhänke*, "We're [in the middle of] hanging a picture"), and also serves as a Konjunktiv II auxiliary for verbs that lack their own synthetic subjunctive form.

Ich tue grad lese.	
I'm reading right now.	

Ich täti gern cho.	
I would like to come. (≈ *würde gerne kommen*)	

Verbs that differ from Standard German

Some verbs are not just phonetically shifted but use a different root altogether. A handful of "false friends" to know:

- *sprechen* → **rede** (*Ich rede Änglisch.*)
- *gehen* (to walk) → **laufe**
- *laufen* (to run) → **renne** or **springe** (Swiss *springe* means both "jump" and "run")

ENGLISH	STANDARD GERMAN	ZÜRICH GERMAN	EXAMPLE
to call up	anrufen	alüte	*Lüt mir a, wenn d acho bisch.* *Ruf mich an, wenn du angekommen bist.*
to look	schauen	luege	*Lueg deet de Elifant!* *Schau, dort der Elefant!*
to listen	(an-, zu-)hören	lose	*Im Zug tueni meischtens Musig lose.* *Im Zug höre ich meistens Musik.*
to work	arbeiten	schaffe	*Ich schaffe bi de SBB.* *Ich arbeite bei der SBB.*
to hurry	sich beeilen	pressiere	*Mir müend pressiere!* *Wir müssen uns beeilen!*

Relative clauses

Zürich German has **exactly one relative pronoun**: *wo* (or *won* before a vowel). Whatever case relationship the relative would mark in Standard German is instead carried by a **resumptive pronoun** elsewhere in the clause.

Resumptive pronouns are **obligatory** for dative, oblique, and possessive relations, but **not used** for subjects or direct objects in standard Zürich usage.

- *wo* + *ich* contracts to **woni**
- *wo* + *mer* (1pl) contracts to **womer**

Subject relative, no resumptive

	The woman who always comes too late.
	Die Frau, die immer zu spät kommt.
	D Frau, wo immer z spaat chunt.

Direct object relative, no resumptive

	A picture that nobody can pay for.
	Ein Bild, das niemand bezahlen kann.
	Es Bild, wo niemert cha zale.

Dative relative, resumptive pronoun

	The boy to whom we promised a bike.
	Der Junge, dem wir ein Fahrrad versprochen haben.
	De Bueb, womer **em** es Velo versproche hend.

Oblique (with preposition), resumptive pronoun

The friend with whom I always go drinking.
Der Freund, mit dem ich immer saufen gehe.
De Fründ, woni immer **mit em** gang go suufe.

Negation

The default marker of negation in the city dialect is **nöd** (in Winterthur and the eastern part of the canton, often *nid*).

Ich wott di nöd gsee.
I don't want to see you.

When the sentence contains an **indefinite noun phrase**, negation is marked by the *negative article* in front of that noun phrase rather than by *nöd*:

Ich wott kä Kafi.
I don't want any coffee.

Negative pronouns and particles

ENGLISH	STANDARD GERMAN	ZÜRICH GERMAN
not	nicht	nöd (city), nid (east)
nothing	nichts	nüt
never	nie	nie
nobody	niemand	niemer
nowhere	nirgends	niene
not anymore	nicht mehr	nüme
not yet	noch nicht	nonig
not even	nicht einmal	nöd emal

Diminutive `-li`

Swiss German is *famously* fond of the diminutive suffix **-li**. It corresponds roughly to Standard German *-chen* / *-lein*, but is far more productive: almost any noun can take it. The plural is invariant (no extra ending).

BASE	HOCHDEUTSCH	DIMINUTIVE	MEANING
Hund	Hund → Hündchen	Hündli	little dog
Chind	Kind → Kindchen, Kindlein	Chindli	little child
Maa	Mann → Männchen, Männlein	Männli	little man
Bizli	ein bisschen	es Bizli / es bitzeli	a (little) bit
Kafi	Kaffee → Käffchen	Käffeli	a (small) coffee
Bier	Bier → Bierchen	Bierli	a (small) beer

Note the typical umlaut: *Hund → Hündli*, *Maa → Männli*, *Kafi → Käffeli*. Many extremely common Swiss nouns are *only* used in diminutive form: *es Müesli*, *es Bizli*, *es Briefli*.

Words that (almost) only exist as *-li*

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ENGLISH
Gipfeli	Croissant	croissant
Guetzli	Plätzchen, Keks	cookie
Müesli	Müsli	muesli
Rüebli	Karotte	carrot
Zältli	Bonbon	sweet, candy
Meitli	Mädchen	girl

Diminutive verbs in *-le*

Verbs take a diminutive too: *-le* makes an activity sound small, cosy or casual.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	EXAMPLE
käfele	gemütlich Kaffee trinken	*Chunsch no cho käfele?* *Kommst du noch Kaffee trinken?*
sünnele	sich sonnen	*Mir sünneled am See.* *Wir sonnen uns am See.*
bröötle	draußen grillieren	*Am Samschtig gömmer go bröötle.* *Am Samstag gehen wir grillieren.*

06 Everyday essentials

The most useful phrases to learn first. Formal forms (used with strangers and older speakers) are marked (*formal*) informal forms are used with friends, family, and most peers.

Hello and goodbye

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	REGISTER	ENGLISH
Grüezi	Grüß Gott / Guten Tag	formal, singular	Hello
Grüezi mitenand	Guten Tag zusammen	formal, plural	Hello (to a group)
Hoi	Hallo	informal	Hi
Sali / Salü	Hallo / Servus	informal	Hi
Tschau	Tschüss / Hallo	informal	Hi / Bye
Uf Widerluege	Auf Wiedersehen	formal	Goodbye
Adieu / Ade	Ade / Auf Wiedersehen	neutral	Goodbye
Tschüss	Tschüss	informal	Bye
Bis spöter	Bis später	informal	See you later
Bis morn	Bis morgen	informal	See you tomorrow

Politeness and pleasantries

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ENGLISH
Merci	Danke	Thanks
Merci vilmal	Vielen Dank	Thanks very much
Bitte	Bitte	Please / You're welcome
Gärn gschee	Gern geschehen	You're welcome (lit. "gladly happened")
Exgüsi / Excuse mer	Entschuldigung	Excuse me
Tschuldigung	Entschuldigung	Sorry
Wie gaht's?	Wie geht's?	How are you?
Mir gaat's guet, danke.	Mir geht's gut, danke.	I'm well, thanks.
Und sälber?	Und selbst?	And yourself?
Was machsch?	Was machst du?	What are you up to?

Survival phrases

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ENGLISH
Ja / Nei	Ja / Nein	Yes / No
Ich verstah nöd.	Ich verstehe nicht.	I don't understand.
Chönd Sie das wiederhole?	Können Sie das wiederholen?	Can you say that again? (formal)
Chasch es bitzli langsamer rede?	Kannst du ein bisschen langsamer sprechen?	Can you speak a bit more slowly? (informal)
Redet Sie Änglisch?	Sprechen Sie Englisch?	Do you speak English? (formal)
Wie seit mer ___ uf Schwyzerdütsch?	Wie sagt man ___ auf Schweizerdeutsch?	How do you say ___ in Swiss German?
Wo isch ___?	Wo ist ___?	Where is ___?
Was choschtet das?	Was kostet das?	What does that cost?
Ich hetti gern ___.	Ich hätte gern ___.	I'd like ___.
D Rächnig, bitte.	Die Rechnung, bitte.	The bill, please.
En Guete!	Guten Appetit!	Enjoy your meal!
Zum Wohl! / Pröschtli!	Zum Wohl! / Prost!	Cheers!

Out and about

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ENGLISH
Isch dä Platz no frei?	Ist dieser Platz noch frei?	Is this seat free?
Chönd Sie mer öppis empfehle?	Können Sie mir etwas empfehlen?	Can you recommend something?
Zum Mitnää, bitte.	Zum Mitnehmen, bitte.	To take away, please.
Chan ich mit Charte zahle?	Kann ich mit Karte zahlen?	Can I pay by card?
Wänn fahrt de nächscht Zug uf Bärn?	Wann fährt der nächste Zug nach Bern?	When is the next train to Bern?
Ich bi nöd vo da.	Ich bin nicht von hier.	I'm not from here.
Kei Problem.	Kein Problem.	No problem.

Numbers

1–10	11–20	TENS
1 **eis** *eins*	11 **elf** *elf*	10 **zää** *zehn*
2 **zwöi** *zwei*	12 **zwölf** *zwölf*	20 **zwänzg** *zwanzig*
3 **drüü** *drei*	13 **drizä** *dreizehn*	30 **drissg** *dreißig*
4 **vier** *vier*	14 **vierzä** *vierzehn*	40 **vierzg** *vierzig*
5 **föif** *fünf*	15 **füfzä** *fünfzehn*	50 **füfzg** *fünfzig*
6 **sächs** *sechs*	16 **sächzä** *sechzehn*	60 **sächzg** *sechzig*
7 **sibe** *sieben*	17 **sibzä** *siebzehn*	70 **sibzg** *siebzig*
8 **acht** *acht*	18 **achzä** *achtzehn*	80 **achzg** *achtzig*
9 **nün** *neun*	19 **nünzä** *neunzehn*	90 **nünzg** *neunzig*
10 **zää** *zehn*	20 **zwänzg** *zwanzig*	100 **hundert** *hundert*

Composite numbers follow the German pattern (ones before tens): *eis-e-zwänzg* (21), *zwöi-e-drissg* (32). Larger units: *hundert* (100), *tuusig* (1,000), *e Milion* (1,000,000).

Days, months, and time of day

ENGLISH	HOCHDEUTSCH	ZÜRICH GERMAN
Monday	Montag	**Mäntig**
Tuesday	Dienstag	**Ziischtig**
Wednesday	Mittwoch	**Mittwuch**
Thursday	Donnerstag	**Dunschtig**
Friday	Freitag	**Friitig**
Saturday	Samstag	**Samschtig**
Sunday	Sonntag	**Sunntig**

am Mäntig = "on Monday". Months are close to Standard German with shifted vowels: *Januar, Februar, März, April, Mai, Juni, Juli, Augscht, Septämber, Oktober, Novämber, Dezämber*. *Hornig* is an older traditional name for February.

Time of day and meals

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	ENGLISH
am Morge	am Morgen	in the morning
am Mittag	am Mittag	at midday
am Namittag	am Nachmittag	in the afternoon
am Abig	am Abend	in the evening
ide Nacht	in der Nacht	at night
hüt	heute	today
geschter	gestern	yesterday
morn	morgen	tomorrow
vorgeschter	vorgestern	day before yesterday
übermorn	übermorgen	day after tomorrow
Zmorge	Frühstück	breakfast
Znüni	Znüni (Imbiss am Vormittag)	mid-morning snack (lit. “at nine”)
Zmittag	Mittagessen	lunch
Zvieri	Zvieri (Imbiss am Nachmittag)	afternoon snack (lit. “at four”)
Znacht	Abendessen	dinner

Telling the time

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	TIME
Wie spaat isch es?	Wie spät ist es?	–
Es isch drüü.	Es ist drei.	3:00
viertel ab drüü	Viertel nach drei	3:15
halbi vieri	halb vier	3:30
viertel vor vieri	Viertel vor vier	3:45
zää ab föifi	zehn nach fünf	5:10

As in Hochdeutsch, *halbi vieri* means 3:30 (half *to* four). From four o’clock on, hours take an *-i*: *um vieri*, *um föifi*, *um sächsi* … *um zwölfi* one to three stay short: *um eis*, *um zwei*, *um drüü*.

07 Vocabulary

A working set of words and phrases that are distinctively Zürich German, either because the root is different from Standard German, or because the word is used with a Swiss-specific meaning.

Verbs

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
luege	schauen	to look	*Lueg deet de Elifant!*
lose	(zu-)hören	to listen	*Im Zug tueni meischtens Musig lose.*
schmöcke	riechen	to smell	*Das schmöckt dänn guet!*
poschte	einkaufen	to go shopping	*Am Samschtig gaat di ganz Familie go poschte.*
laufe	(zu Fuss) gehen	to go on foot	*Nämed mer de Bus oder laufed mer?*
springe	rennen / laufen	to run (also: jump)	*Er isch devoogsprunge.*
tschuute	Fussball spielen	to play football	*Min Fründ gaat jede Samschtig go tschuute.* (from English *to shoot*)
lisme	stricken	to knit	*Sii het sich e Chappe glismet und er en Schaal.*
glette	bügeln	to iron	*Ich mues na Wösch glette.*
brüele	weinen	to cry	*Ufem Spiilplatz brüelet es Chind.*
chlüübe	kneifen	to pinch	*S Lisi het mi in Aarm gchlobe.*
plagiere	angeben / prahlen	to show off	*Hör doch uf plagiere, du Schnori!*
verchare	überfahren	to run over (with a vehicle)	*Mis Büsi isch vercharet worde.*

Health & body

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
Pfnüsel	Schnupfen	a cold	*Im Früelig plaaget en de Höipfnüsel.*
Chopfweh	Kopfschmerzen	headache	*Ich ha sit em Morge Chopfweh.*
Buuchweh	Bauchschmerzen	stomach ache	*S Chind het Buuchweh.*
Spital	Krankenhaus	hospital	*Si liit im Spital.*

Money & travel

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
Stutz	Franken; Geld	franc; money (colloquial)	*Das choschtet föif Stutz.*
Bileet	Fahrkarte / Eintrittskarte	ticket (transport, event)	*Ali Bileet, bitte!*
Rappe	Rappen (1/100 Franken)	centime	*Ich ha kei Rappe meh.*
Bancomat	Geldautomat	ATM, cash machine	*Gits da i de Nööchi en Bancomat?*
Halbtax	Halbtax-Abo	half-fare travel card	*Hesch es Halbtax?*

People & mild insults

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
Tubel	Idiot	idiot	*Du bisch en Tubel!*
Sibesiech	ausgefuchster Kerl	cunning guy	*De Felix, de Sibesiech, het dä Stier igfange!*
Siech (VULG.)	(Mist-)Kerl	guy (orig. “a sick person”; can be affectionate or rude)	*Du bisch en blööde Siech! Er isch en glatte Siech!*
Säich (VULG.)	Unsinn (eig. Urin)	nonsense (lit. piss; vulgar)	*Red nöd eso-n-en Säich.*

Food & cooking

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
Härdöpfel	Kartoffel	potato	*Uf dem Fäld wachsed Härdöpfel.*
Härdöpfeltampf	Kartoffelbrei	mashed potatoes	*Si macht eso-n-en guete Härdöpfeltampf.*
Böle	Zwiebel	onion	*Aazele Böle schelle, d Chatz gaat uf Walisele.*
Binätsch	Spinat	spinach	*Vil Chind hend Binätsch nöd gern.*
Chabis	Kohl; Unsinn	cabbage; nonsense	*Red ekei Chabis!*
Barile	Aprikose	apricot	*Barilegomfi und Barilewääen isch öppis Guets.*
Wää(j)e	Blechkuchen (Wähe)	flat fruit tart	*Friitig isch Wäätaag.*

Animals & nature

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
Büsi	Katze	cat	*Ich hett gern es Büsi.*
Röiel	Kater	tomcat	*De Röiel röilet.*
Chrottepösche	Löwenzahn	dandelion	*D Wisen isch vole Chrottepösche.*
Müllerblüemli	Gänseblümchen	daisy	*Di ganz Wisen isch wiiss vor luuter Müllerblüemli.*

Adjectives & qualifiers

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
gruusig	eklig	gross / disgusting	*Iii, isch das gruusig.*
heimlifeiss	harmlos wirkend, …	sneaky (looks harmless but isn't)	*Du bisch scho na heimlifeiss.*
uu	sehr	very	*Das isch uu nett vo dir!*
echli	ein wenig	a little	*D Musig isch mer echli z luut.*

Household & objects

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
Glettise	Bügeleisen	iron (the appliance)	*Zum Glette bruucht mer es Glettise.*
Chlüppli	Wäscheklammer	clothes pin	*Zum d Wösch uufhänke bruucht mer Chlüppli.*
Zäine	Wäschekorb	laundry basket	*Die frisch Wösch liit zemeggläit i de Zäine.*
Schoppe	(Baby-)Fläschchen	baby bottle	*Gib em Chind de Schoppe!*
Chlüüre	Murmel (aus Glas)	marble	*En Hegel und e Hampfle Chlüüren im Hosesack.*
Sidele	Stabelle (Holzstuhl)	three-legged stool	*Di Sidele isch zweihundertfüfzg Jaar alt.*
Winde	Dachboden	attic	*Uf de Winde hets en Huuffe Grümpel.*

Pronouns, particles & function words

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
öpper	jemand	somebody	*Öpper het mis Portmonee gstole.*
öppis	etwas	something	*Ich wett der öppis schänke.*
öppe	etwa	roughly / about	*Das choscht öppe hundert Franke.*
nöime(t)	irgendwo	somewhere	*Hesch nöimet miini Ziitig gsee?*
daa	hier	here	*Wie lang bliibed Si daa?*
amig(s)	jeweils	each time / regularly	*Am Wuchenänd gaat er amigs go wandere.*
ufe, ue	herauf, hinauf	up (toward / away)	*Uf dää Gipfel ue müemer chräsme.*
abe	herunter, hinunter	down	*D Chatz trout sich nümen abem Baum abe.*
Schoche	Haufen	pile / heap	*Ganz Schöche Härdöpfel esse.*

Around town

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
Beiz	Kneipe, Wirtshaus	pub, simple restaurant	*Gömmer no i d Beiz?*
Badi	Freibad	outdoor pool, lido	*Im Summer simmer jede Tag i de Badi.*
Beck	Bäcker(ei)	baker's	*Ich hol no Gipfeli bim Beck.*
Metzg	Metzgerei	butcher's	*Hol bitte d Wurscht i de Metzg.*
Lade	Laden, Geschäft	shop	*De Lade isch am Sunntig zue.*
Chreis	Stadtkreis	city district (Zürich has 12)	*Ich wohne im Chreis föif.*
Gmeind	Gemeinde	municipality, town hall	*Ich mues mich bi de Gmeind aamälde.*
Kiosk	Kiosk	newsagent's	*Am Kiosk gits Ziitige und Zältli.*

Everyday expressions

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	EXAMPLE
Das isch mer Wurscht.	Das ist mir egal.	I don't care.	*Wohi gömmer? – Mir isch Wurscht.*
gäbig	praktisch, handlich	handy, practical	*Das Messer isch gäbig.*
Jäsoo!	Ach so!	Oh, I see!	*Jäsoo, jetzt verstahn ich's.*
Kei Ahnig.	Keine Ahnung.	No idea.	*Wo isch de Schlüssel? – Kei Ahnig.*
Hopp!	Los! / Auf geht's!	Come on! / Go!	*Hopp Schwiiz!*
Es gaht.	Es geht so.	So-so.	*Wie gaht's? – Es gaht.*
Uf jede Fall.	Auf jeden Fall.	Definitely.	*Chunsch au? – Uf jede Fall!*

French and English loanwords

Swiss German has borrowed extensively from French (particularly from Romandie, the French-speaking part of Switzerland) and more recently from English. Many of these words mark Swiss vocabulary as distinct from Standard German.

Most of these keep French spelling but take Swiss first-syllable stress: *VE-lo, TRO-ttoir, PER-ron*.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	STANDARD GERMAN	ENGLISH	ORIGIN
Velo	Fahrrad	bicycle	French
Trottoir	Gehweg	sidewalk	French
Coiffeur	Friseur	hairdresser	French
Glace	Eis	ice cream	French
Poulet	Hähnchen	chicken	French
Confiture / Gomfi	Marmelade	jam	French
Billett	Fahrkarte	ticket	French
Merci	Danke	thanks	French
Quartier	Stadtteil	neighborhood	French
Apéro	(none)	pre-dinner drinks & snacks	French
Salär	Gehalt	salary	French
Etage	Stockwerk	floor (of a building)	French
Natel	Handy	mobile phone	Swiss coinage
Lift	Aufzug	elevator	English
Tram	Straßenbahn	tram	English
Goalie	Torwart	goalkeeper	English
Penalty	Elfmeter	penalty kick	English
Match	Spiel	match / game	English
Pneu	Reifen	tyre	French
Perron	Bahnsteig	platform	French
Trottinett	Tretroller	kick scooter	French
Jupe	Rock	skirt	French
Lavabo	Waschbecken	washbasin	French
Occasion	Gebrauchtwagen / Schnäppchen	used car / bargain	French

Particles and flavor words

Discourse particles are short, often untranslatable words that carry tone, register, or attitude. Using them is what makes Swiss German sound like Swiss German rather than Standard German with shifted vowels.

PARTICLE	HOCHDEUTSCH	ROUGH MEANING	EXAMPLE
gäll / gel	gell / nicht wahr	"right?" (confirmation tag)	*Schön, gäll?* ("Nice, right?")
halt	halt / eben	"just" (resignation, "that's how it is")	*Das isch halt eso.* ("It's just like that.")
eh	eh / sowieso	"anyway" (something already known)	*Ich gang eh i d Stadt.* ("I'm going into town anyway.")
doch	doch	"after all" / contradiction	*Du chunsch doch?* ("You're coming, right?")
jo / ja	ja	soft "you know" (not just "yes")	*S isch jo nöd schlimm.* ("It's not that bad, you know.")
scho	schon	"already" / "indeed"	*Das isch scho schwierig.* ("That is rather difficult.")
au	auch	"also"	*Ich gang au.* ("I'm going too.")
na	noch	"still" / "yet"	*Ich bin na nöd parat.* ("I'm not ready yet.")
emol	einmal / mal	"once" / "sometime"	*Chum emol verbii.* ("Come by sometime.")
denn	denn	"then"	*Was machsch denn hüt?* ("What are you doing today, then?")
oder	oder? / nicht wahr?	"right?" (very Swiss tag)	*Das isch guet, oder?* ("That's good, isn't it?")
äbe	eben	"exactly" / "that's the point"	*Äbe!* ("Exactly!")
dänk	doch, natürlich	"of course" / "surely"	*Das isch dänk klar.* ("That's obvious, of course.")
glaub	glaube ich	"I think" (softener)	*Er chunt glaub morn.* ("I think he's coming tomorrow.")
eifach	einfach	"just" / "simply"	*Mach's eifach!* ("Just do it!")

False friends and pitfalls

Words that exist in Standard German but mean something different in Swiss German, or that differ enough in form to trip up a learner who knows German.

SWISS GERMAN	MEANS	PITFALL
laufe	to walk	In Standard German *laufen* means "to run". In Swiss German walking is *laufe* running is *renne* or *springe*.
springe	to run (also: to jump)	Both meanings coexist; context disambiguates.
luege	to look	Not *schauen schauen* is rarely used.
lose	to listen	Not *zuhören*. Unrelated to Standard German *los*.
Rüebli	carrot	Not *Karotte* or *Möhre*. The Swiss term.
Glace	ice cream	Pronounced French-style (*glah-suh*), not as in English "glaze".
Schoggi	chocolate	Not *Schokolade* in everyday speech.
Velo	bicycle	*Velo* is the everyday Swiss word; *Fahrrad* is understood but marks the speaker as non-Swiss.
Billett	ticket (transport, event)	Not *Führerschein* despite older usage; the standard meaning is "ticket".
parkieren	to park (a car)	Standard German is *parken* the *-ieren* form is Swiss.
grillieren	to grill	Standard German is *grillen* same *-ieren* Swissism.
Anke	butter	Some speakers use *Anke* instead of *Butter*, especially rurally.
schmöcke	to smell	Standard German *schmecken* means "to taste". *Das schmöckt guet* = it smells good.
hebe	to hold	Standard German *heben* means "to lift". *Heb mal!* = hold this!
Estrich	attic	In Germany *Estrich* is floor screed. In Switzerland it's the attic.
zügle	to move house	Not *ziehen umziehen* is understood but sounds German.
Sack	pocket (*Hosesack*)	Not just "bag": *im Hosesack* = in the trouser pocket.

08 Sample sentences

	We went fishing and caught lots of fish.
	Wir gingen angeln und fingen viele Fische.
	Mir sind go fische ggange und hend vil Fisch gfange.

	I want to buy the kitten we saw at the pet shop.
	Ich will das Kätzchen kaufen, das wir in der Tierhandlung gesehen haben.
	Ich wett s Chetzli chaufe, wo mer ide Tierhandlig gsee hend.

	Shall we go for a coffee after work?
	Gehen wir nach der Arbeit einen Kaffee trinken?
	Gömmer nach de Arbet go en Kafi trinke?

	I'm quickly going shopping, do you need anything?
	Ich gehe schnell einkaufen, brauchst du etwas?
	Ich gang schnäll go poschte, bruuchsch öppis?

	Yesterday it rained all day, so we stayed at home.
	Gestern hat es den ganzen Tag geregnet, darum sind wir zu Hause geblieben.
	Geschter het's de ganz Tag grägnet, drum sind mer dihei bliibe.

	Could you tell me where the train station is?
	Könnten Sie mir sagen, wo der Bahnhof ist?
	Chönnted Sie mer säge, wo de Bahnhof isch?

09 Sample dialogue

A casual conversation between two friends planning a trip to Zürich. Each turn is given in Zürich German, Standard German, and English.

A Hesch gwüsst, eusi Kollegin d Barbara hüratet nächst Wuche.

Hast du gewusst, unsere Kollegin Barbara heiratet nächste Woche.
You know, our colleague Barbara is getting married next week.

B Ja, sie het mich au iglade. Bisch schomal z Züri gsii?

Ja, sie hat mich auch eingeladen. Warst du schon mal in Zürich?
Yes, she invited me too. Have you ever been to Zürich?

A Nei, ich bin nonie z Züri gsii.

Nein, ich war noch nie in Zürich.
No, I've never been to Zürich.

B Wie wär's, wenn mer zeme deet ane fahred?

Wie wäre es, wenn wir gemeinsam dorthin fahren?
How about we go there together?

A Das isch e sehr gueti Idee.

Das ist eine sehr gute Idee.
That's a very good idea.

B Wie wämmer uf Züri fahre? Mitem Zug?

Wie wollen wir nach Zürich fahren? Mit der Bahn?
How do you want to get to Zürich? By train?

A Nei, mitem Zug gaht's z lang und mir müend viel umstiige.

Nein, mit der Bahn dauert es lange und wir müssen viel umsteigen.
No, by train it takes a long time and we have to change trains a lot.

B Mir chönnted au mitem Auto fahre. Was meinsch?

Wir könnten mit dem Auto fahren. Was sagst du dazu?
We could go by car. What do you say?

A Das isch en guete Vorschlag.

Das ist ein guter Vorschlag.
That's a good suggestion.

B Hesch du en Stadtplan vo Züri?

Hast du einen Stadtplan von Zürich?
Do you have a map of Zürich?

10 Sounding Swiss: Aussprache & intonation

If you already speak German, grammar and vocabulary are the easy part. What gives you away is **how** you say things. Most of it comes down to a handful of Hochdeutsch habits that you have to unlearn.

This section is for German speakers. It is ordered by how much each habit gives you away. Everything describes the **Zürich** norm; Bern, Basel and the Valais differ in places (Bernese, for example, turns *l* into *u*: don't copy that here). IPA is given in `[brackets]` where it helps; the descriptions work without it.

The ten biggest giveaways

HOCHDEUTSCH HABIT	ZÜRICH TARGET	EXAMPLE
Aspirated *p, t, k* (a puff of air)	No aspiration: plain, crisp *p, t, k*	**Tram, Tee, Poscht**
ich-Laut `[ç]` after front vowels	Always the back *ach*-sound `[x]`	**ich, rächt, Milch**
r swallowed at the end (*Wassa*)	*r* always pronounced	**Wasser, Bier, Vatter**
Glottal stop before every vowel	Words glide into each other	**am Abig** → "a-mabig"
ie, ue, üe as long single vowels	Real two-part diphthongs	**lieb, guet, müed**
Long vowel in open syllables	Often short, consonant long	**Vatter, Ofe, Bode**
Stress at the end of French loans	Stress on the first syllable	**Velo, Büro, Billett**
Voiced *b, d, g*	Voiceless but soft (lenis)	**Bode, Dach, Gaarte**
Clear *-en* endings	*-e*, final *n* dropped	**mache, Garte, Wage**
Fast, clipped, flat melody	Slower, even, more pitch movement	**Grüezi mitenand**

Before you start: record a baseline

Read this short passage aloud in Zürich German and record it. Do it again after working through this section; the difference is the best motivation there is.

	Am Samschtig bin ich mit minere Fründin uf Züri gfahre. Mir sind zerscht am See gsii und denn i d Altstadt go käfele. Am Abig hemmer im Niederdorf znacht gesse und sind spaat hei.
	Am Samstag bin ich mit meiner Freundin nach Zürich gefahren. Wir waren zuerst am See und dann in der Altstadt Kaffee trinken. Am Abend haben wir im Niederdorf zu Abend gegessen und sind spät nach Hause gegangen.

Listen back for: a puff of air on *t* in *Altstadt*, an *ich*-Laut in *ich*, a swallowed *r* in *Samschtig* and *Abig*, a glottal stop before *Abig* and *Altstadt*, and *See* said with a long German *ee* instead of a closed Swiss *e*.

Plosives: fortis and lenis, never aspirated

This is the single biggest accent marker. In Hochdeutsch, *p*, *t*, *k* at the start of a stressed syllable come with a puff of air (`[pʰ tʰ kʰ]`), and *b*, *d*, *g* are voiced. Zürich German has **neither**. The contrast is instead between **fortis** (tense, long: *p*, *t*, *k*, *pp*, *tt*, *gg*) and **lenis** (lax, short, but still voiceless: *b*, *d*, *g*).

SOUND	HOCHDEUTSCH	ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOW TO PRACTISE
t / *p*	*Tee* `[tʰeː]`, *Post* `[pʰɔst]`	**Tee** `[teː]`, **Poscht** `[poʃt]`	Hold a sheet of paper in front of your mouth. It must **not** move on the *t* or *p*.
b / *d* / *g*	voiced: *Boden* `['boːdn̩]`	**Bode** `['b̥oːd̥ə]`: no voice, just a soft, short closure	Whisper the word, then say it normally without adding voice to the consonant.
k at the start	*Kaffee* `['kʰafe]`	**Kafi** `['kxafi]`: *k* with a little *ch* after it	Say "k" and slide straight into a short *ach*-sound before the vowel.
gh, *gg* (from *ge-*)	*gehabt*, *gegangen*	**ghaa** `[kʰaː]`, **ghört** `[kʰœrt]`; **ggange** `['kːaŋə]`, **ggää**	*g* + *h* is one of the few places where you **do** get a puff of air. *gg* is a long, tense *k*.

Because *b*/*d*/*g* and *p*/*t*/*k* are both voiceless, the difference you hear is length and tension. Lean into it: a long *tt* in **Vatter** or *pp* in **Suppe**, a short soft *d* in **Bode**.

Long consonants (geminates)

Double letters in Swiss German really are long: you hold the consonant noticeably longer, the way Italian does. In Hochdeutsch *Wasser*, the *ss* only marks a short vowel; in Zürich **Wasser** it is a long `[s:]`. Often the vowel in front is short *because* the consonant is long.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	LISTEN FOR
Wasser `['ʊas:ər]`	Wasser	long *ss*, full *-er*
Vatter `['fat:ər]`	Vater	short *a*, long *tt*
offe `['of:ə]` vs. **Ofe** `['ofə]`	offen vs. Ofen	the only difference is the length of *f*
Chatz `[xat:s]`	Katze	*tz* = long *t* + *s*
ässe `['æs:ə]`	essen	very open *ä*, long *ss*
Chuchi `['xʊx:i]`	Küche	long *ch* in the middle

ch is always at the back

Hochdeutsch has two *ch* sounds: the front *ich*-Laut `[ç]` (*ich, Milch, Kirche*) and the back *ach*-Laut `[x]` (*Bach, Buch*). Zürich German has **only the back one**, and often pronounces it even further back and rougher (`[x]`). On top of that, every native word that starts with *k* in Hochdeutsch starts with this sound.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	TIP
ich `[ɪx]`	ich `[ɪç]`	Say *ach*, then keep the tongue there and change only the vowel to *i*.
Milch `[mɪlx]`	Milch `[mɪlç]`	Same in **rächt** (recht), **Chilche** (Kirche), **Liecht** (Licht).
Chind `[xɪnd̥]`	Kind	Initial *ch* is a strong friction noise, never a *k*.
Chuchichäschtli	Küchenschränkchen	The classic test word: three back *ch*, an open *ä*, and *scht*.

r is pronounced, every time

In Hochdeutsch the *r* after a vowel melts into a vowel: *Wasser* is `['vasɐ]`, *Bier* is `[biːɐ̯]`, *wird* sounds like *wiad*. In Zürich German the *r* stays a consonant. In the city most people use a uvular *r* at the back of the throat (`[ʁ]`); a rolled tongue-tip *r* (`[r]`) is also common, especially in older and rural speakers. Both are fine. What matters is that you can **hear** it.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	LISTEN FOR
Bier `[biər]`	Bier `[biːɐ̯]`	diphthong *ie*, then a real *r*
Tüür `[tyːr]`	Tür	long *üü*, audible *r*
wird `[vɪrd̥]`	wird	no *wiad*
Mueter `['mʊətər]`	Mutter	*-er* ends in *r*, not *a*

🇨🇭	Ich ha vier Bier trunke.
🇩🇪	Ich habe vier Bier getrunken.
🇬🇧	I drank four beers. (Drill: four audible *r* sounds.)

More consonants: *scht*, final *n*, *w*

s before *t* and *p* is always *sch*

Hochdeutsch only says *scht* and *schp* at the start of a word (*Stein*, *Sport*). Zürich German does it **everywhere**: in the middle and at the end of words too. Germans who get everything else right often slip back into a plain *st* here.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH
isch, **bisch**, **hesch**	ist, bist, hast
Fescht, **Poscht**, **Wurscht**	Fest, Post, Wurst
Chaschte, **geschter**, **Kaschper**	Kasten, gestern, Kasper
du muesch, **du wottsch**	du musst, du willst

Final *n*: gone, until a vowel follows

Word-final *n* after an unstressed vowel disappears: **mache, Garte, Wage, choo**. Don't half-pronounce it; it's simply not there. But when the next word starts with a vowel, the *n* comes back as a link, which is why you hear *ich bi-n-i* but *ich bi müed*.

BEFORE A CONSONANT	BEFORE A VOWEL	HOCHDEUTSCH
Ich bi müed.	**Ich bin echli müed.**	Ich bin (ein bisschen) müde.
e Frau	**en Apfel / en Öpfel**	eine Frau, einen Apfel
Mir gönd go schwümme.	**Gönd er au?**	Wir gehen schwimmen. Geht ihr auch?

w is softer, *v* is usually *f*

Zürich *w* is a light approximant (`[ʋ]`): the lower lip only *approaches* the upper teeth, with almost no friction. A strong German *w* (`[v]`) sounds heavy in **Wasser, Wii, Wuche**. Native words with *v* are said with *f* as in Hochdeutsch (**Vatter, vil, vo**); only loanwords like **Velo** have a soft *v*.

Consonant workout

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	FOCUS
Ich ha de Chaschte uf d Poscht bracht.	Ich habe den Kasten zur Post gebracht.	*ch*, *scht* ×2, unaspirated *p*, *t*
Wer wott no es Wasser?	Wer will noch ein Wasser?	soft *w* ×3, long *ss*, audible *r*
Chum, mir müend pressiere!	Komm, wir müssen uns beeilen!	initial *ch*, no *n* in *pressiere*
Isch d Wurscht scho fertig?	Ist die Wurst schon fertig?	*d* + *W* cluster, *scht*, *r*
Wie spaat isch es?	Wie spät ist es?	*schp* in *spaat*, soft *w*, no aspiration
Gib mer bitte de Chäs.	Gib mir bitte den Käse.	soft *b*, *d*, *g*, unaspirated *t*, back *ch*
Hesch de Peter gsee?	Hast du Peter gesehen?	*gs* cluster, unaspirated *p*, *t*, full *-er*
Mir sitzed im Garte.	Wir sitzen im Garten.	no final *n*, short *a*, audible *r*

Vowels and diphthongs

The vowel system is where Swiss German sounds most "different". Three things matter: the **falling diphthongs** *ie*, *ue*, *üe*, the **very open ä**, and the fact that *ii*, *uu*, *üü* are pure long vowels with no glide.

SOUND	ZÜRICH EXAMPLES	HOCHDEUTSCH	HOW TO MAKE IT
ie [iə]	**lieb, Brief, Chriesi**	lieb, Brief, Kirsche	Two parts: *i* gliding into a short *e*/schwa, like English "*here*" without the *r*. Never a plain long *i*.
ue [uə]	**guet, Bueb, Fuess**	gut, Bub, Fuß	*u* gliding into schwa: "goo-et" squeezed into one syllable.
üe [yə]	**Grüezi, müed, früe**	Grüß Gott, müde, früh	*ü* gliding into schwa. The *üe* in **Grüezi** is the most-heard sound in the city.
ä [æ]	**Chäs, Bärg, Wäg, ässe**	Käse, Berg, Weg, essen	Much lower than Hochdeutsch *ä*: close to English "*cat*". Open the jaw.
ii [i:]	**Wii, Ziit, Schwiiz**	Wein, Zeit, Schweiz	Pure long *i*, no *ai* glide at all.
uu [u:]	**Huus, Muus, uuf**	Haus, Maus, auf	Pure long *u*, no *au*.
üü [y:]	**Tüütsch, hüt, Fründ**	Deutsch, heute, Freund	Long (or short) *ü*, no *eu* glide.
ei [ei]	**Stei, Bei, hei**	Stein, Bein, heim	Starts on a closed *e*, not on *a*. Sounds "thinner" than Hochdeutsch *ei*.
öi [øi]	**föif, Höi, öis**	fünf, Heu, uns	Start on *ö*, glide to *i*.

The test pair for Germans: **Liebi** (love) is *li-ə-bi*, two clear movements in the first syllable. Hochdeutsch *Liebe* `['li:bə]` in a Swiss sentence is instantly noticeable.

Vowel contrast drill

Say each pair aloud: first the Hochdeutsch word, then the Zürich one. Exaggerate the difference at first.

HOCHDEUTSCH	ZÜRICH GERMAN	WHAT CHANGES
Liebe ['li:bə]	**Liebi** ['liəb̥i]	long *i* → two-part *ie*
gut [gu:t]	**guet** [uət]	long *u* → two-part *ue*
Wein [vaɪn]	**Wii** [ʋi:]	diphthong → pure long *i*
Haus [haʊs]	**Huus** [hu:s]	diphthong → pure long *u*
Berg [bɛʁk]	**Bärg** [b̥æɾ̊]	*e* → very open *ä*, real *r*

Vowel length: short where Hochdeutsch is long

Hochdeutsch lengthened vowels in open syllables centuries ago (*Vater, Boden, leben*). Zürich German mostly did not, so these words have a **short** vowel, often followed by a long consonant. Saying them with a long vowel is one of the most typical German-speaker mistakes.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	NOTE
Vatter	Vater `['fa:te]`	short *a*, long *tt*, full *r*
Ofe	Ofen `['o:fn̩]`	short *o*
Bode	Boden	short *o*, soft *d*
läbe	leben	short, very open *ä*

Unstressed vowels are not swallowed either. Final *-i* (**Chuchi, Liebi**) and the diminutive *-li* (**Bierli**) keep a clear *i* *-e* is a short schwa, but it never disappears the way Hochdeutsch *-en* collapses to *-n*.

Stress: first syllable, even in French words

Swiss German stresses the **first syllable** of most words, including the many French loanwords that Hochdeutsch stresses at the end. This is one of the quickest wins: the spelling stays French, the stress moves to the front.

WORD	HOCHDEUTSCH / FRENCH STRESS	ZÜRICH STRESS
Büro	Bü-**RO**	**BÜ**-ro
Telefon	Tele-**FON**	**TE**-le-fon
Billett	Bil-**LETT**	**BIL**-lett
Garage	Ga-**RA**-ge	**GA**-rasch
Portemonnaie	Portemon-**NAIE**	**PORT**-mo-nee
Merci	mer-**CI**	**MER**-ci
Velo	(Fahrrad)	**VE**-lo
Abbreviations: SBB, ETH, UBS	S-B-**B** (last letter)	**S**-B-B (first letter)

Linking: no glottal stops, words run together

Hochdeutsch puts a small catch in the throat (a *glottal stop*) before every word that begins with a vowel: *am | Abend*, *er | isst | ein | Ei*. Zürich German does **not**. Consonants slide into the next vowel, short articles and pronouns attach to the neighbouring word, and a linking *-n-* appears to avoid two vowels meeting.

PATTERN	ZÜRICH GERMAN	SOUNDS LIKE	HOCHDEUTSCH
No glottal stop	**am Abig**	*a-mabig*	am Abend
Linking *-n-*	**wie-n-e Chind**	*wiene Chind*	wie ein Kind
Linking *-n-*	**ich bi-n-en gsee**	*bin-en*	ich habe ihn gesehen
Pronoun attaches	**han i → hani**	*hani*	habe ich
Pronoun attaches	**gönd mir → gömmer**	*gömmer*	gehen wir
Pronoun attaches	**sind mir → simmer**	*simmer*	sind wir
Pronoun attaches	**wenn du → wenn d**	*wennd*	wenn du
Pronoun attaches	**tue ich → tueni**	*tueni*	tue ich

Article clusters

The short articles *d* (die) and *s* (das), and the preposition *z* (zu/in), have no vowel. They fuse with the first consonant of the next word into clusters that Hochdeutsch doesn't have. Don't insert a schwa (*de Frau*) and don't pause: say it as one block.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	PRONOUNCED	HOCHDEUTSCH
d Frau	[tfrau]	die Frau
d Tüür	[t:y:r]: one long *t*	die Tür
d Mueter	[tmuətər]	die Mutter
s Huus	[shu:s]	das Haus
s Chind	[sxɪnd̥]	das Kind
z Züri	[ts:yri]: long *ts*	in Zürich

The prefix *ge-* works the same way: **gsii** (gewesen), **gmacht** (gemacht), **gseit** (gesagt) are single-syllable clusters, and before *b*, *d*, *g*, *k*, *p*, *t* the *g* disappears or merges: **bracht** (gebracht), **trunke** (getrunken), **ggange** (gegangen).

Melody, rhythm and tempo

Germans often describe Swiss German as *singend*. Three things create that impression, and you can work on each one separately.

- **Slower, more even tempo.** Swiss speech gives syllables more equal time; it is less "stress-timed" than northern Hochdeutsch, where unstressed syllables are squashed. Long consonants and full diphthongs need that time, so slowing down makes the other sounds easier as well.
- **More pitch movement, later peaks.** In Hochdeutsch the pitch peak usually sits right on the stressed syllable and falls immediately. Swiss dialects tend to rise *through* the stressed syllable and peak later, often on the following syllable, before falling. Bernese is the extreme case; Zürich is milder but still clearly more melodic than Hochdeutsch.
- **Soft endings.** Statements end with a gentle, drawn-out fall rather than a clipped stop. Don't cut the last syllable short, and don't end with a glottal stop.

PHRASE	WHAT TO DO WITH THE MELODY
Grüezi.	Stress on *Grüe*: start fairly low, glide up through the *üe* diphthong, and fall on *-zi*. A flat, quick "Grützi" sounds German.
Uf Widerluege!	Main stress on *lue*. Give the *ue* diphthong its full length and let the pitch fall gently over *-ge*.
Schön, gäll?	Fall on *Schön*, then a small rise on *gäll*: it asks for agreement.
Merci vilmal!	Stress *MER-ci*, then a second, stronger stress on *vil*. Slightly sing-song, not clipped.
Chunsch au?	Yes/no questions often end with a rise-fall rather than the steep final rise of Hochdeutsch *Kommst du auch?*
Hoi zäme!	Two light stresses, *HOI* and *ZÄ-me*, with a friendly fall at the end. Said quickly and flat, it sounds cold.
Ah, würkli?	Surprise: a big rise-fall on *würk-*. A flat version sounds bored or sarcastic.

Drill sentences

Each sentence targets several of the points above. Say them slowly first, record yourself, and compare with a native Zürich speaker. Then speed up without losing the sounds.

ZÜRICH GERMAN	HOCHDEUTSCH	FOCUS
Grüezi mitenand.	Guten Tag zusammen.	*üe* diphthong, unaspirated *t*, soft ending
Mir gönd go poschte.	Wir gehen einkaufen.	no aspiration on *p*/*t*, *scht*, open *ö*
Am Abig gömmer is Kino.	Am Abend gehen wir ins Kino.	linking (*a-mabig*), *gömmer*, *k* + *ch* in *Kino*
Ich ha vier Bier trunke.	Ich habe vier Bier getrunken.	audible *r* ×4, *ie* diphthong, *-e* for *-en*
Es Chuchichäschtli voll Chäschüechli.	Ein Küchenschrank voller Käsetörtchen.	back *ch* ×5, open *ä*, *üe*
D Rächnig, bitte.	Die Rechnung, bitte.	*d* + *R* cluster, open *ä*, back *ch*
Ziit für es Bierli?	Zeit für ein Bierchen?	pure long *ii*, *ie* diphthong, clear *-li*
De Vatter isch im Gaarte.	Der Vater ist im Garten.	short *a* + long *tt*, *isch*, full *-er*
Ich bi-n-en geschter gsee.	Ich habe ihn gestern gesehen.	linking *-n-*, *gs* cluster, *scht*
Merci vilmal, uf Widerluege!	Vielen Dank, auf Wiedersehen!	first-syllable stress on *Merci*, *ue* diphthong, melody

A practice routine

1. **Shadowing.** Take 20–30 seconds of a Zürich speaker and repeat it with the same rhythm and melody, daily for a week.
2. **Record and compare.** Record yourself on the drill sentences above. Listen specifically for puffs of air on *p*/*t*/*k*, an *ich*-Laut, a missing *r*, or a glottal stop.
3. **Hum the melody.** Hum a sentence without words to copy its pitch contour, then add the words back.
4. **Ask for correction.** Most Swiss people switch to Hochdeutsch as soon as they hear a German accent. Tell them you're learning and ask them to stay in dialect and correct your pronunciation.

11 Resources

The fastest way to train your ear is real Swiss German. Most of the films and series are on **Play Suisse**, SRF's free streaming service; radio and podcasts are on the SRF website and in podcast apps. Not everything is Zürich German: the dialect is noted where it differs.

Films

TITLE	WHAT IT IS	WHY IT'S USEFUL
Die Schweizermacher (1978)	Comedy	Classic satire about becoming Swiss.
Achtung, fertig, Charlie! (2003)	Army comedy	Light, quotable, young people's dialect.
Mein Name ist Eugen (2005)	Family adventure	Fun boys' road trip; Bernese dialect.
Die Herbstzeitlosen (2006)	Comedy drama	Pensioners open a lingerie shop; Bernese.
Schweizer Helden (2014)	Comedy drama	Refugees stage *Wilhelm Tell*.
Die göttliche Ordnung (2017)	Drama	Women's suffrage in 1971; clear speech.
Wolkenbruch (2018)	Comedy	Orthodox Jewish life in Zürich.
Zwingli (2019)	Historical drama	The Reformation in Zürich.
Platzspitzbaby (2020)	Drama	The 1990s Zürich drug scene.

Series

TITLE	WHAT IT IS	WHY IT'S USEFUL
Der Bestatter (2013–2019)	Crime	Long-running SRF hit; lots to binge.
Wilder (2017–2022)	Crime thriller	Dark SRF crime series.
Neumatt (2021–)	Family drama	Farm life near Zürich; natural dialogue.
Tschugger (2021–)	Comedy	Very funny, but in Valais dialect.

Things to do

- **Take a course**: the Klubschule Migros and many adult education centres offer Schweizerdeutsch classes.
- **Find a tandem partner**: trade your English for their Swiss German, and ask them to correct your accent.
- **Switch your input**: SRF 3 on the commute, SRF Meteo every evening.

Radio, TV and podcasts

TITLE	WHAT IT IS	WHY IT'S USEFUL
SRF 3	Radio station	Presenters speak dialect all day.
SRF Meteo	Weather forecast	Short, daily, same phrases every day.
Glanz & Gloria	Celebrity news	Light topics, fast everyday speech.
Giacobbo / Müller	Satire show	Classic SRF satire, 2008–2016.
Deville	Late-night show	Current SRF comedy and interviews.
Zytlupe	Satire podcast	Weekly satire; humour and idioms.
Input	SRF 3 podcast	Half-hour everyday documentaries.
Debriefing 404	Tech podcast	SRF's tech and internet show.
Zivadiliring	Talk podcast	Three friends chatting; natural speech.
Easy Swiss German	YouTube	Street interviews with subtitles.

Music

REGION	ARTISTS
Zürich	Bligg (rap and pop), Dabu Fantastic (pop)
Central	Hecht (pop), Mimiks (rap)
Basel	Baschi (pop)
Bern	Patent Ochsner, Züri West (despite the name), Lo & Leduc, Stiller Has, Steff la Cheffe, Trauffer

Books and tools

TITLE	WHAT IT IS	WHY IT'S USEFUL
Zürichdeutsche Grammatik	Grammar (A. Weber)	The classic Zürich German grammar.
Zürichdeutsches Wörterbuch	Dictionary	Zürich German ↔ Hochdeutsch.
Kleiner Sprachatlas der deutschen Schweiz	Dialect atlas	Maps of regional word forms.
Schweizerisches Idiotikon	Dictionary	idiotikon.ch; the big historical one.
Dialäkt Äpp	App (UZH)	Guesses your dialect from a few words.

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